

UPrep Model United Nations 2025



UNCTAD

United Nations Conference on Trade and Development



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Director's Letter

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD) at UPrepMUN 2025! It is with great enthusiasm that we gather to delve into the critical issue of fast fashion and its affect on child labor and the environment. Our discussions will focus on creating sustainable solutions for clothing production, addressing unethical labor practices in the textile industry, and ensuring the overall transparency in the supply chain. We will explore the complexities of international cooperation, the role of governments and NGOs, and the impact of policy decisions on the lives of both workers and consumers. At the end of the conference, we will hold a fashion show runway to celebrate our collaborative achievements! Thank you for your commitment to addressing these pressing global issues. We anticipate a productive and insightful session.

All the best,

Anousha Mukherjee, Chair
Halle Hollon, Assistant Director

Committee Overview

The United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD) was founded in 1964 to promote equitable global trade and ease the integration of developing nations into the international market. UNCTAD plays a crucial role in shaping trade policies, offering debt management, and fostering safe business practices. It also serves as a platform for collaboration, research, and building consensus on global trade issues, especially those affecting the Global South. Over the decades, UNCTAD has expanded its reach by working closely with governments, the civil society, and the private sector to create inclusive trade systems that support long-term development. Recently, the committee has turned its attention to fast fashion. Emerging in the late 90s, fast fashion is the mass production of cheap clothing to align with topical trends. Its business model encourages overconsumption, as retailers prioritize speed and low costs over sustainability and ethical practices. The industry is responsible for huge amounts of waste, environmental degradation, and the exploitation of workers. Garment workers, particularly in developing countries, often face unsafe working conditions, unfair wages, and limited labor protections. The environmental impact includes excessive water use, pollution from toxic dyes, and the release of microplastics into oceans. In this committee, countries must find ways to balance economic growth with protecting workers and the planet. Delegates will need to consider regulatory measures, trade incentives, and international cooperation to hold corporations accountable while still allowing for development and innovation in the textile industry.

Topic A:

The Impact of Fast Fashion on Child Labor and the Environment

Topic Introduction

Fast fashion is a massive, fast-growing industry that has nearly doubled the number of garments produced each year over the past two decades. The term was first used at the beginning of the 1990s, when Zara landed in New York. The term “fast fashion” was coined by the New York Times to describe Zara’s mission to allow garments to go from the design stage to being sold in stores in just 15 days. The biggest players in the fast fashion world include Zara, Shein, UNIQLO, Forever 21, and H&M. Recently, global fashion consumption has increased by 400%, with waste and pollution occurring throughout every step of the production process. This industry harms wildlife, degrades ecosystems, and significantly contributes to climate change—accounting for up to 10% of global CO₂ emissions. Animal-based fabrics like wool also carry an environmental cost, contributing to greenhouse gas emissions, deforestation, and water pollution. In fast fashion, wool is often mixed with fossil fuel-based fibers and treated with chemicals, making these garments even more damaging to produce and dispose of. The fast fashion model thrives on overproduction, overconsumption, and exploitation. To meet demand for trendy, low-cost clothes, vast quantities of raw materials are consumed, leading to major waste and pollution. These garments often have short lifespans due to poor quality, and are either incinerated, dumped in landfills, or shed microplastics into waterways. Beyond environmental harm, fast fashion also relies on human exploitation. Workers—often young women in low-income countries—face unsafe working conditions and are paid far below a livable wage, despite the massive profits earned by companies. Even as both consumers and brands claim to prioritize sustainability, fast fashion continues to grow unchecked. Companies like Shein release up to 1,000 new styles daily, with 50–100 pieces made per design—adding up to at least 50,000 new garments a day. Transforming this industry means shifting away from the glamorization of overconsumption and toward a fashion culture rooted in sustainability and justice.

Past Action

As the environmental and human rights consequences of fast fashion became more visible in the early 21st century, the United Nations began taking steps to address its growing impact. UNCTAD, in particular, has emphasized the need for sustainable trade practices in the textile and garment industries. Recognizing the dual threat fast fashion poses to both environmental integrity and human rights, UNCTAD has hosted high-level discussions and produced reports calling for greater transparency in supply chains and the protection of vulnerable workers.

One notable development was the 2013 UN Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights, endorsed by the UNHRC, which urged companies to prevent labor abuses, including child labor, in their supply chains. While not legally binding, these principles have since influenced national legislation and corporate codes of conduct in the fashion industry. In 2019, during UNCTAD's Forum on Sustainable Fashion, the organization pushed for circular economy approaches and highlighted the importance of trade policy in curbing waste and emissions. This forum encouraged member states to reexamine trade incentives that favor overproduction and environmental degradation.

Additionally, the ILO-UNCTAD Joint Initiative on Decent Work in Global Supply Chains was launched to promote better working conditions, with a focus on sectors like apparel where labor violations are common. This initiative has contributed to broader efforts, such as the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, particularly SDG 8 (Decent Work and Economic Growth) and SDG 12 (Responsible Consumption and Production). More recently, the UN General Assembly adopted Resolution A/RES/76/202, which calls for strengthening sustainable and resilient supply chains, indirectly addressing fast fashion's overreliance on cheap, exploitative labor and environmentally harmful practices. However, enforcement remains a challenge, and gaps persist in global efforts to hold fast fashion actors accountable.

Current Situation

Fast fashion has rapidly transformed the global garment industry, enabling companies to design, produce, and ship clothing within as little as 2 weeks—compared to the traditional 2-month production cycle. Brands now launch new collections on a monthly or even weekly basis, responding to consumer demand at unprecedented speeds. This acceleration has altered global supply chains and created pressure for low-cost production. One of the most prominent companies associated with this model is Shein, which uses predictive analytics and claims to minimize waste by producing based on demand. However, the volume of production is staggering—Shein alone releases over 1.5 million styles per year, compared to traditional retailers' 1,000 or the 20,000 by first-generation fast fashion brands like Zara and H&M.

Despite pledges for sustainability and ethical production, less than 1% of fashion textiles are recycled. Each year, three out of every five garments are incinerated or end up in landfills. This environmental crisis is compounded by the fact that no central tracking exists on the number of garments produced globally, making efforts to reduce the industry's carbon footprint especially difficult. Initiatives like the Or Foundation's Speak Volumes campaign, which encourages brands to disclose production volumes, have seen limited participation—only 32 small and medium-sized businesses have disclosed data, while major corporations remain silent.

In response to these concerns, countries are beginning to implement legislation. France has passed a bill to ban advertising for fast fashion and impose penalties per item sold, while also pushing for a European Union-wide ban on exporting used clothing. New York State has proposed a law requiring brands to map and keep their supply chains transparent. Although some companies are trying to reposition themselves—Shein by launching a marketplace for secondhand “hand me down” clothing and Zara by pledging to use sustainable materials by 2025—the fundamental structure of fast fashion remains intact. The effects of overproduction are particularly visible in places like Kantamanto Market in Accra, Ghana, where up to 40% of imported used textiles become waste.

Factors contributing to overproduction include minimum order requirements from manufacturers, the failure of demand forecasting, and pressure to constantly introduce new products. Technologies like AI-based demand prediction and made-to-order systems exist but have not been adopted at scale. While many brands claim to have targets for reducing overproduction, implementation is slow and vague. Without transparency and enforceable commitments, the social and environmental toll of fast fashion continues to grow—affecting not only ecosystems but also the communities, particularly in the Global South, where labor exploitation and environmental dumping often intersect.

Case Studies

CAMBODIA

Cambodia's garment industry accounts for over 80% of the country's total exports, employing approximately 850,000 workers, the majority of whom are women from rural areas. Many of these workers are subject to unsafe conditions, forced overtime, and wage violations. The Labour Law of 1997, while providing some protections, is often weakly enforced. The Trade Union Law of 2016 has been criticized for restricting workers' rights to organize unions. Additionally, textile dyeing factories often discharge untreated wastewater into the Mekong and Tonlé Sap Rivers, violating national environmental standards. In response, Cambodia launched the Switch Garment Project in 2021, aimed at promoting cleaner production in textile factories, but progress has been slow due to limited monitoring capacity.

GHANA

Ghana imports an estimated 15 million items of second-hand clothing per week, much of which comes from the US and Europe under the name "Obroni Wawu" or "dead white man's clothes." These imports, mostly unsellable fast fashion waste, overwhelm Accra's Kantamanto Market, where up to 40% of garments become landfill waste or are burned, releasing microplastics and toxic chemicals into the environment. The country has no comprehensive textile waste law, but the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) of Ghana has started drafting regulations to manage solid waste imports. In 2023, environmental groups like the Or Foundation advocated for a ban on textile dumping and the creation of an Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) system to hold exporting countries accountable.

EL SALVADOR

El Salvador is a key garment producer in Central America, with its industry employing around 75,000 people and exporting over \$2.5 billion worth of goods annually, primarily to the US under CAFTA-DR (Central America-Dominican Republic Free Trade Agreement). Many workers face poor conditions, with reports of verbal abuse, wage theft, and union suppression. In 2022, the Ministry of the Environment proposed Norma Técnica Salvadoreña, a technical regulation for industrial water discharge, targeting textile pollution. While enforcement is still developing, El Salvador is beginning to take steps toward holding factories accountable for environmental harm and labor violations.

Bloc Positions

Low-Income Countries: Main Exporters and Producers of Clothing:

Bangladesh, Cambodia, Honduras, India, Indonesia, Kenya, Nigeria, Pakistan, Philippines, Ukraine, Vietnam

These nations are major garment producers due to low labor costs and large workforces. They often face labor exploitation and pollution from textile production. This bloc may push for increased international support, fair trade access, and gradual industry reform.

Middle-Income Countries: Supporters of Sustainability and Labor Rights:

Brazil, Colombia, Costa Rica, El Salvador, Mexico, South Africa, Turkey, Argentina, Chile, Uruguay

Balancing production and reform, these countries face both economic reliance on fashion exports and internal calls for labor and environmental standards. This bloc may advocate for responsible trade practices and capacity-building partnerships.

High-Income Countries: Main Exporters and Advanced Manufacturers

China, Germany, Italy, Japan, Poland, South Korea, United States

These nations lead in textile technology, high-end fashion, and machinery exports, often outsourcing low-cost production abroad. This bloc may support innovation, transparency in supply chains, and green development incentives.

High-Income Countries: Main Consumers of Clothing

Australia, Canada, France, Norway, Spain, Sweden, United Kingdom, Netherlands, Denmark

As major consumers, these countries drive demand and generate textile waste. Some already have laws targeting fashion sustainability. This bloc may push for consumer awareness, corporate accountability, and sustainable fashion policies.

Guiding Questions

1. What trade and labor policies can countries adopt to ensure ethical practices in the fast fashion industry?
2. How can developing countries benefit economically from fast fashion without sacrificing workers' rights?
3. What environmental regulations should countries enforce to reduce the pollution caused by textile production?
4. What incentives can governments provide to fashion companies that use eco-friendly materials and ethical labor practices?
5. How can global supply chains be made more transparent to hold fast fashion brands accountable for labor violations?
6. What role can technology and innovation play in making the fashion industry more sustainable?
7. How can countries balance economic growth from fashion exports with environmental protection goals?
8. What education and training opportunities can help garment workers transition to greener and safer jobs?
9. How can international organizations like UNCTAD support smaller nations in enforcing labor and environmental protections in fast fashion?

Further Research

UNCTAD website – <https://unctad.org/about>

Environmental cost –

<https://news.un.org/en/story/2019/03/1035161>

Harms of fast fashion –

https://www.biologicaldiversity.org/programs/population_and_sustainability/sustainability/fast_fashion

Circular economy textiles –

https://unctad.org/news/seizing_opportunities-circular-economy-textiles

Detrimental effect on environment –

<https://earth.org/fast-fashions-detrimental-effect-on-the-environment/>

Fashion brands to avoid –

<https://www.sustainably-chic.com/blog/fast-fashion-brands-to-avoid>

How to reduce fast fashion –

<https://www.sustainyourstyle.org/en/reducing-our-impact>

UN alliance fast fashion –

<https://unfashionalliance.org/>

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